

ANEMONES AND CORALS

Unlike other cnidarians, the Anthozoa lack the free-swimming medusa stage altogether and most remain static throughout their life cycle. The polyps, many of which have a flower-like appearance, produce sperm and eggs. Members of this class include solitary anemones, colonial sea pens, soft corals, and tropical reef-forming stony corals.

20–30 cm
8–12 in

slender red or
yellow lobe

1–6 m
3½–20 ft

TOADSTOOL LEATHER CORAL

Sarcophyton trocheliophorum
F: Alcyoniidae

This soft coral can form enormous leathery colonies on tropical reefs of the Indo-Pacific. It is fast-growing, nourished by photosynthetic algae.

white
polyps

10–20 cm
4–8 in

RED DEAD-MAN'S FINGERS

Alcyonium glomeratum
F: Alcyoniidae

This is a more slender, upright ally of dead-man's fingers, found on sheltered rocky European coastlines. It varies from yellow to red.

COMMON DEAD-MAN'S FINGERS

Alcyonium digitatum
F: Alcyoniidae

A typical soft coral, this thickly lobed European species has colonies of polyps, which are carried on a fleshy mass unsupported by a rigid skeleton.

0.5–2 m
1½–6½ ft

WHITE SEA WHIP

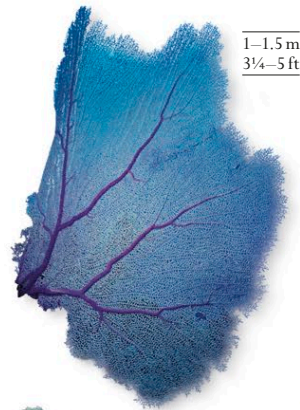
Junceella fragilis
F: Ellisellidae

Sea whips are thread-like relatives of sea fans, with their supporting horny axis reinforced with calcium. This is an Indonesian reef species.

RED SEA WHIP

Ellisella sp.
F: Ellisellidae

Ellisella sea whips form two-prong branching colonies, some of which may form dense underwater bushes. They occur in tropical and temperate waters.



1–1.5 m
3¼–5 ft

COMMON SEA FAN

Gorgonia ventalina
F: Gorgoniidae

Sea fans, such as this Caribbean species, have upright fan-like colonies supported by a central axis, which is stiffened with a horny substance called gorgonin.

polyp cluster

20–30 cm
8–12 in

SEA STRAWBERRY

Gersemia rubiformis
F: Nephtheidae

This stalked soft coral forms bright pink lumpy colonies. It occurs in northern parts of the Pacific and Atlantic Oceans.

10–15 cm
4–6 in

CARNATION CORAL

Dendronephthya sp.
F: Nephtheidae

Typical of a family of stalked soft corals with polyps arranged in clusters, this colourful species occurs on Indo-Pacific tropical reefs.

50–100 cm
20–40 in



RED CORAL

Corallium rubrum
F: Coralliidae
Colonies of this Mediterranean sea fan (not a true coral) are supported by a skeleton of tiny, enmeshed calcified needles. It is valued for jewellery.

flexible
body

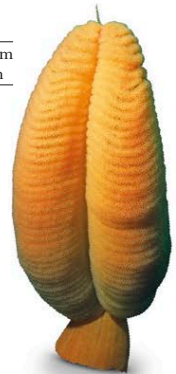
35–40 cm
14–16 in

KIDNEY SEA PEN

Sarcoptilus grandis
F: Pennatulidae

Widespread in temperate waters, this sea pen has kidney-shaped branches that occur in rows along each side of its body.

40–50 cm
16–20 in



ORANGE SEA PEN

Ptilosarcus gurneyi
F: Pennatulidae

One of many brightly coloured sea pens, this species from the Pacific coast of N. America retracts into its burrow when disturbed by predators.

calcareous
tubes

15–30 cm
6–12 in



ORGAN PIPE CORAL

Tubipora musica
F: Tubiporidae

This Indo-Pacific soft coral has polyps in upright, calcified tubes, which are connected to the colony by a root-like network at the base.

BLUE CORAL

Heliopora coerulea
F: Helioporidae

Despite its hard, calcified skeleton, this species is more closely related to soft coral than stony coral. It is the only member of its order.

tentacle

